Even in more modern times, their destinies have been linked by global political currents that brought India back into the picture. Singapore, in fact, is a particularly telling example of how the future of contemporary India was shaped in South-East Asia during the Second World War. In the years thereafter, as they all achieved independence, ASEAN leaders cooperated and competed as they set about fashioning their national prospects. And India was a point of relative agreement compared to other powers who were more divisive.

What really changed in 1992 was that a relationship which was largely harmonious but only moderately energetic was now suddenly charged by a new economic imperative. This was, thereafter, taken forward by a series of policy initiatives, including a number of free trade agreements. Investment and trade flows between ASEAN and India have been steadily growing with Singapore as the principal hub. Businesses from this region occupy a prominent position in the Indian economy across a broad range of activities, spanning telecommunications and aviation to logistics, road building, industrial parks, and finance. On their part, Indian companies have a presence in energy, commodities, infrastructure and banking. The expansion of connectivity between India and South-East Asia is both a driver and an outcome of these collaborations. Indeed, over the last twenty-five years, the inter-penetration and travel between ASEAN and India has been so extensive that most Indians now intuitively think of this region as part of their neighbourhood.

This relationship has gone well beyond its economic and even cultural dimensions. There are thirty mechanisms between India and ASEAN, including an annual summit and seven ministerial dialogues. From the Indian perspective, ASEAN occupies a central place in the security architecture of the Asia-Pacific region. It is the considered Indian view that precisely because ASEAN represents the cultural, commercial and physical crossroads of the region, it has a unique ability to reflect and harmonize larger interests of the world beyond it. We have seen this already in the workings of the ASEAN Regional Forum (ARF), of which India became a member in 1996. There was even greater appreciation of the criticality of ASEAN to the larger continental stability when it conceptualized and implemented the East Asia Summit process. India was one of its original